

**When to Ask for Help: The Effect of Perceived Norms and Sense of Belonging on
Support-Seeking Intentions**

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Abstract

Academic, social, and basic needs resources that are provided to students by universities aren't always utilized by those in need. The current study aims to measure the impact of perceived norms and sense of school belonging on students' willingness to seek support in the form of university resources. Through a Qualtrics survey, 92 undergraduate students at UCSB were randomly primed with either a high or low support-seeking norm and completed two sets of questions that measured their sense of belonging and support-seeking intentions. There was no significant effect of perceived norm or sense of belonging on support-seeking intentions. Additionally, there was no significant interaction between the two variables. These findings challenge current theories that suggest that students who perceive support-seeking as a norm and/or report a higher sense of belonging will demonstrate higher support-seeking intentions.

Keywords: perceived norm, sense of belonging, support-seeking intention

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Universities provide resources such as academic advising, health care, and career counseling to their students in order to support their success. These resources are funded by student tuition, so it is important that they are accessible and useful for students. However, many college students struggle with social and academic support-seeking because of stigmatization, embarrassment, and a desire to protect personal information (Barksdale & Molock, 2009). As a result, students often neglect to use the academic and social resources provided by their university. The present study aims to identify barriers to support-seeking and, ultimately, campus resource utilization in college students. Specifically, this study measures how perceived norms and sense of belonging influence support-seeking intentions in college students. By addressing these key factors, universities can make better informed marketing decisions when communicating campus resources to students. Changes implemented based on the findings of this study may lead to an increase in the number of students utilizing and benefiting from campus resources.

Perceived Norms

The Theory of Planned Behavior states that human behavior is influenced by three factors: behavioral beliefs, control beliefs, and normative beliefs (Bosnjak et al., 2020). Normative beliefs concern an individual's understanding of the regular behaviors and social expectations of others (Schultz et al., 2008). According to this theory, normative beliefs lead to ideas about subjective (perceived) norms, which are often related to feelings of social pressure. For the purposes of this study, we define perceived norms as an individual's beliefs about the behavior they should engage in, modeled after the behaviors of the group majority. The desire to

follow norms is motivated by one's need to fit in (Schultz et al., 2008). Previous research has demonstrated the consistent finding that norms impact both help-seeking intentions and behavior (Barksdale & Molock, 2009). For example, African American college students are intrinsically held back from seeking mental health support by the fear of being perceived in a negative light by their social circle (Barksdale & Molock, 2009). This in part stems from the belief that seeking mental health support is atypical (not a normative behavior) and should be a secretive affair (Barksdale & Molock, 2009). Believing that the majority of other students do not rely on mental-health support is an example of a norm, which has created the social pressure to manage problems independently. This finding is in accordance with the Theory of Planned Behavior, as the decision to not seek out support is dictated by normative beliefs (Bosnjak et al., 2020). Thomas and Tagler (2019) found that students report significantly higher intentions to seek academic help when they believe that other high-achieving students also use campus support resources. This suggests that if students were primed with the idea that many of their peers utilize student services, causing them to perceive support-seeking as a norm, they would be more inclined to do the same.

One limitation of the supporting literature is the range of methods used to measure support-seeking intentions and behaviors. Previous research on the topic has defined students' support-seeking behaviors through a narrow scope, emphasizing engagement in an exclusively academic domain (Thomas & Tagler, 2019). The present study employs a more general definition of support-seeking by measuring intentions for support-seeking in a broader range of areas, such as in finance, wellness, and food security. This provides an opportunity for practical application of survey findings to other campus departments, such as Financial Aid, Health and Wellness, and Basic Needs. By expanding the definition of support-seeking, we open up a larger

discussion about barriers students face when deciding whether to seek support for any personal, social, or academic problems.

Sense of Belonging

Another factor that has been found to influence support-seeking intentions is one's sense of belonging to a given community. We define the sense of belonging in an academic context as an individual's sense of membership, involvement, and affiliation with their university. The innate desire to belong is a strong driving force behind many human behaviors, as it has a significant effect on cognitive processes and emotional patterns (Beaumeister & Leary, 1995). Walton and Cohen (2007) found that Black college students who received an intervention that protected their sense of belonging by leading them to believe they would have friends within their major were more likely to communicate with their professors, which is a key example of academic support-seeking. Other studies have found that sense of belonging is positively correlated to adaptive help-seeking in college students. In close relation to sense of belonging, social support has also been associated with a higher level of support seeking intentions (Nagai, 2015). These studies echo the finding that positive feelings about one's community, such as level of belongingness and prevalence of a social support system, foster a 'safe' environment for support-seeking. Conversely, these findings suggest that individuals who do not have a strong membership and association with their school will be less inclined to seek support and utilize campus resources catered to them.

A major gap in research on this topic is the absence of an established cause-and-effect relationship between sense of belonging and support-seeking intentions. Most research on sense of belonging employs a correlational design, rather than an experimental design with a manipulated variable. Additionally, many previous studies measuring the effects of sense of

belonging in education focus on academic achievement outcomes, rather than support-seeking intentions or behaviors (Abdohllahi & Noltemeyer, 2016). There is also limited research on the effects of belongingness on support-seeking in non-academic areas, such as mental health and food security, which the present study aims to address.

Current Study

The current study explores the effects of perceived norms and sense of belonging on support-seeking intentions. Building off of the key finding that norms influence support-seeking behaviors in wellness and academia, this study manipulates participants' normative beliefs about student utilization of university resources, such as counseling services and academic advising, to measure the effect this has on their intentions to seek support. Taking into consideration the omnipresent influence of one's sense of belonging to their larger community, we also measure each participants' sense of belonging to their university. Given the previous literature, we predicted that participants who are primed with the high support-seeking norm would demonstrate higher support-seeking intentions than participants who are primed with the low support-seeking norm. We predicted that participants who report a high sense of school belonging would also demonstrate high-support seeking intentions. Additionally, we predicted that the effect of high-support seeking norms would be more pronounced in students who report a high sense of school belonging, while students who report a low sense of school belonging would not be affected by the perceived norms priming passage.

Method

Participants

The participants for this study were 92 undergraduate students between the ages of 18 and 26 ($M=20.4$, $SD=1.2$), attending the University of California, Santa Barbara. Participants

were openly recruited from social media posts on Instagram, Snapchat, and GroupMe. From our sample, 27.6% of participants identified as Asian/Pacific Islander, 54.3% Caucasian, 7.6% Hispanic/Latino, 2.9% Black/African American, 1.0% Native American, and 6.7% identified as two or more races. Our sample included seven males (7.78%) and 83 females (92.22%), while two participants chose not to report their gender. Participation in this study was voluntary and participants were not compensated for their time.

Design

We conducted a 2 (perceived norms: high support-seeking versus low support-seeking) X 2 (sense of belonging: high versus low) experimental, between-subjects design. Our dependent variable was support-seeking intentions, operationalized by the degree to which participants rated their intention to seek support in twelve hypothetical situations. Our key mediator was sense of school belonging, operationalized by 12 items from the Sense of Social Fit Scale (Walton & Cohen, 2007).

Measures

Perceived Norms

We randomly primed participants with a passage that presented information about the prevalence of support-seeking in the form of campus resource utilization in undergraduate students at UCSB. The high-support seeking passage stated that 81% of students who struggle with personal and emotional problems have utilized Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS) and 75% of students have utilized Campus Learning Assistance Services (CLAS) and found these resources to be helpful. The low-support seeking passage stated that 19% of students who struggle with personal and emotional problems have utilized CAPS and 24% of students have utilized CLAS and found these resources to be helpful. These passages were intended to

prime students with the idea that support-seeking is either common or uncommon among their peers, potentially influencing their own intentions to utilize similar campus resources. This stimulus was modeled after the normative messages Schultz et al. (2008) created to promote towel reuse among hotel guests in order to measure normative social influence. Schultz et al. (2008) observed a significant change in the conservation behavior of hotel guests who viewed a normative message that included both descriptive and injunctive elements. As such, we used a similar format to develop our priming passage.

Support-Seeking Intentions

We assessed our dependent variable, participants' support-seeking intentions, through an original 12-item scale that measured students' agreement with statements about utilizing campus resources. The following three items were included in the scale: (a) "If I was struggling to sign up for classes, I would intend to speak to an academic advisor." (1 = *strongly disagree* to 5 = *strongly agree*), (b) "If I was struggling to pay for groceries, I would intend to utilize the AS Food Bank," and (c) "If I was experiencing a health concern, I would intend to visit the Student Health Center." The wording of the statements was modeled after the Mental Help Seeking Intention Scale (Hammer & Spiker, 2018). Scores were composited and evaluated for mean and standard deviation values. Higher mean scores on this scale indicated a greater willingness to seek support in the form of campus services, while lower mean scores indicated a reluctance to seek campus support.

Sense of Belonging

We measured our moderator, sense of school belonging, through a shortened version of the Sense of Social Fit Scale (Walton & Cohen, 2007). We selected 12 out of 17 items from the Sense of Social Fit Scale to include in our survey in order to match the number of items in the

support-seeking intentions scale and keep the study length below five minutes in length. We selected items that best measured sense of belonging at UCSB. The following three items were included in the scale: (a) “I fit in well at UCSB.” (1 = *strongly disagree* to 5 = *strongly agree*), (b) “I belong at UCSB,” and (c) “I feel like an outsider at UCSB.” This scale quantifies an individual’s sense of belonging to a group and has previously been used on first-generation college students and college students of a diverse ethnic background (Walton & Cohen, 2007). Scores were composited and evaluated for mean and standard deviation values. Higher mean scores on this scale indicate a stronger sense of school belonging, while lower mean scores indicate a weaker sense of school belonging.

Procedure

Participants completed a short Qualtrics survey. After opening the anonymous survey link, they were directed to the consent form. If they consented to participate in the study, participants completed the shortened Sense of Social Fit Scale (Walton & Cohen, 2007). They were then prompted to read either the high- or low-support seeking priming passage, which was randomly assigned to them. The stimuli was followed by a short manipulation check that asked the participants to confirm the percentage of student resource utilization of CAPS. The participants then completed a set of 12 questions that measured their support-seeking intentions. Finally, participants answered three demographic questions (age, gender, ethnicity) and were presented with a debriefing form that described the purpose of the study, signaling their completion of the study.

Results

The current study measured the effect of perceived norms and sense of belonging on UCSB students’ support-seeking intentions. Twelve items (e.g., “I fit in well at UCSB.”) were

used to measure participants' sense of belonging, with questions 1, 2, and 5 reverse coded. Using the median split procedure (median=4.0), participants were categorized into either the high sense of belonging group ($n=46$) or low sense of belonging group ($n=46$). The reliability was high, $\alpha=0.890$. Twelve items (e.g., "If I was struggling to pay for groceries, I would intend to utilize the AS Food Bank.") were used to measure participants' support-seeking intentions. They were averaged to create a composite score for the factor and had a high reliability, $\alpha=0.840$.

We then conducted a perceived norm (high support seeking versus low support seeking) X sense of belonging (high versus low) ANOVA with support-seeking intentions as a dependent variable. There was no significant effect of perceived norm on support-seeking intentions, $F(1, 91)=0.067, p=0.796, n^2_p=0.001$. Such that ratings of support-seeking intentions in the high perceived norm condition ($M=3.520, SD=0.862$) did not significantly differ from the low perceived norm condition ($M=3.360, SD=0.630$). There was no significant effect of sense of belonging on support-seeking intentions, $F(1, 91)=1.026, p=0.314, n^2_p=0.01$. Such that ratings of support-seeking intentions in the high sense of belonging condition ($M=3.460, SD=0.826$) did not significantly differ from the low sense of belonging condition ($M=3.420, SD=0.689$). Finally, there was no significant interaction between perceived norm and sense of belonging on support-seeking intentions, $F(1, 91)=0.75, p=0.39, n^2_p=0.001$. These results show that perceived norms and sense of belonging do not affect UCSB students' support-seeking intentions. See figure one for the reported findings.

Discussion

The current study found no significant effect of perceived norm or sense of belonging on support-seeking intentions in students as UCSB. Additionally, there was no significant

interaction effect between perceived norm and sense of belonging on support-seeking intentions.

Theoretical and Practical Implications

This study provides contrasting evidence against current theories in the literature that suggest that perceived norm and sense of belonging predict support-seeking intentions (Barksdale & Molock, 2009). Our results do not support the Theory of Planned Behavior, as the intended behavior of participants in the current study did not appear to be influenced by the priming of normative beliefs (Bosnjak et al., 2020). We did not find any evidence of an effect of normative beliefs on support-seeking intentions, as reported by Barskdale and Molock (2009). Additionally, our results contest the finding that a stronger sense of belonging is correlated with higher academic support-seeking intentions (Walton & Cohen, 2007).

The practical implication of this study is that it demonstrates that students' sense of school belonging and perception about the utilization of campus resources among their peers does not impact their support-seeking intentions. Universities can use these results when identifying factors that may affect utilization of campus resources. The current study demonstrates the complexity of support-seeking intentions and the varying levels of influence perceived norms and sense of belonging have on students. After viewing these results, universities may be less inclined to employ descriptive and injunctive messages when advertising campus resources, as perceived norms do not seem to affect intentions to utilize these resources. Instead, universities may consider other factors that influence student resource utilization, such as academic year, cultural background, and campus involvement.

Limitations

There are various limitations to the current study. Because we used a Qualtrics questionnaire as our means of collecting data, our findings may not be the most accurate

reflection of support-seeking intentions. Some students may lack the self-awareness required to accurately predict their behavior in a hypothetical situation. Students may also have presentational concerns about reporting feelings of ostracization and insecurity when completing the sense of belonging scale. One way to combat this effect is to emphasize the anonymity and confidentiality of survey responses. Another limitation to the study is the lack of diversity in our sample pool, which was predominantly white, female students at UCSB. A larger sample with greater gender and ethnic diversity would be a better representation of the student population at UCSB, increasing the external validity of the study. A final limitation to all studies measuring support-seeking intentions is the disconnect between intentions and behavior. In order to address this, researchers should follow up with participants to confirm whether support-seeking intentions resulted in support-seeking behavior.

Future Research

Although the current findings call into question the importance of perceived norms and sense of belonging on support-seeking intentions, there is strong evidence to support the connection between these variables in previous literature (Thomas & Tagler, 2019). Future studies should further explore the effect of perceived norms and sense of belonging on students' willingness to seek support in the form of campus resources. We encourage future studies to use a more thorough manipulation of perceived norms, perhaps by showing participants a video that either praises or criticizes the utility and popularity of campus resources. In order to increase the internal validity of the study and obtain more robust findings, future studies should employ a more effective manipulation check, such as a perceived norm scale. Future studies should measure intentions to use resources that are personally helpful to participants and follow-up with participants after the initial survey to assess if their intentions resulted in support-seeking

behaviors. Finally, future research in this area should focus on establishing a causal relationship between the given factors by designing experimental studies.

Conclusion

Campus resources must be accessible, helpful, and well-advertised in order to maximize student usage of them. Understanding the factors that prevent students from seeking academic and social support will help universities make informed decisions when designing and marketing these resources. It's possible that targeting students' perception of resource utilization among their peers may increase their likelihood of using campus resources themselves. It's also possible that students who feel ostracized or disconnected from their campus community are less likely to utilize resources available to them. We hope to garner more interest in this topic within the social psychology field in order to ensure that students who need support feel comfortable enough to seek it.

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Tables and Figures

Figure 1*Effect of Perceived Norms and Sense of Belonging on Help-Seeking Intentions*